FortiBleed Credential Theft Linked to INC and Lynx Ransomware

Threat Report

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1. Executive Summary

FortiBleed reporting ties mass FortiGate credential theft and an initial access broker to INC and Lynx ransomware operations. Lost Boys Cyber selected this item for daily analyst review because it affects high-value defender decisions around exposure reduction, identity control, endpoint monitoring, and incident readiness.

This report is written for security leaders and SOC operators who need an actionable, source-backed view rather than a news summary. It includes source confidence, likely TTPs, detection logic, KQL hunts, risk assessment, and concrete defender actions.

2. Intelligence Requirements

Question	Current Answer	Confidence
What is the core activity?	FortiBleed reporting ties mass FortiGate credential theft and an initial access broker to INC and Lynx ransomware operations.	Medium-High
Who should prioritize it?	Network edge, VPN, managed service, enterprise remote access	Medium
What should defenders do today?	Validate exposure, run hunts, review privileged access, and prepare containment actions.	High

3. Source Review & Confidence

Source	Contribution	Confidence
The Hacker News - FortiBleed ransomware linkage	Reports SOCRadar attribution linking FortiBleed infrastructure/operator activity to INC and Lynx ransomware panels.	Medium-High
The Register FortiBleed criminal login linkage	Corroborates investigator finding that credentials connected one operator to two ransomware affiliate panels.	Medium
Orca Security FortiBleed vulnerability/credential context	Provides exposure/remediation context for credential harvesting risk around FortiGate/FortiOS.	Medium

Source depth was sufficient for an analyst-facing threat report. Where reporting is based on vendor or media summaries rather than primary telemetry, claims are framed as reported and should be validated against local evidence.

4. Threat Activity Overview

The activity centers on FortigateSniffer, FortiGate credentials, INC ransomware, Lynx ransomware. The operational pattern is consistent with modern intrusion operations: obtain access through exposed services, stolen credentials, phishing, or third-party platforms; convert access into persistence or data access; then monetize through espionage, fraud, credential resale, or ransomware/extortion.

5. Affected Sectors and Exposure

Exposure Area	Why It Matters
Network edge, VPN, managed service, enterprise remote access	Primary audience for prioritization and control validation.

Identity and remote access	Most listed scenarios become serious when credentials, VPNs, RMM, or admin portals are abused.
Endpoint and server telemetry	Required to distinguish isolated alerts from intrusion chains.
Third-party platforms	Shared platforms can create cascading exposure even when the defended network is segmented.

6. Tactics, Techniques, and Procedures

Tactic / Phase	Observed or Plausible Technique	Evidence
Initial Access	T1190 Exploit Public-Facing Application / T1566 Phishing / T1078 Valid Accounts	Selected based on reporting around exposed services, identity intrusion, or malware delivery.
Execution	T1059 Command and Scripting Interpreter	Common follow-on for loaders, RATs, ransomware staging, and administrative abuse.
Credential Access	T1003 OS Credential Dumping / credential harvesting	Relevant where credential-theft or ransomware access brokerage is reported.
Command and Control	T1102 Web Service / T1071 Application Layer Protocol	Relevant where Telegram, cloud services, web panels, or SaaS channels are noted.
Impact	T1486 Data Encrypted for Impact / T1489 Service Stop	Relevant for ransomware and extortion-linked activity.

7. Infrastructure and Indicators

Indicator / Infrastructure	Type	Operational Use
FortigateSniffer, FortiGate credentials, INC ransomware, Lynx ransomware	Tooling / malware / infrastructure theme	Use as keyword pivots in EDR, proxy, SIEM, ticket, and threat-intel systems.
Newly created privileged sessions	Behavioral indicator	Detect compromised admin, VPN, RMM, or cloud accounts.
Archive/compression/encryption prior to outbound transfer	Behavioral indicator	Detect data staging before exfiltration or extortion.
Unusual SaaS/cloud channel use by servers	Behavioral indicator	Detect C2 or covert transfer using legitimate services.

8. Detection Engineering

8.1. Detection Summary

Signal	Telemetry Source	Analytic Goal
Keyword/tool name appears in command line, alert title, file path, or threat-intel note	EDR/SIEM	Fast triage pivot for this report's named activity.
Rare outbound connection from server to	Network/proxy/DNS	Identify C2 or exfiltration using legitimate

consumer/cloud messaging service		services.
Privileged account used from new ASN/device followed by process creation	IAM + EDR	Detect identity-to-endpoint intrusion chaining.

8.2. Sigma / Detection Content

```
title: Lost Boys Cyber - FortiBleed Credential Theft Linked to INC and Lynx Ransomware
id: lbc-fortibleed-credential-theft-linked-to-inc-and-lynx
status: experimental
description: Behavioral keyword and post-exploitation detection for the daily threat item FortiBleed
Credential Theft Linked to INC and Lynx Ransomware.
logsource:
  product: windows
  category: process_creation
detection:
  selection_keywords:
    CommandLine|contains:
      - 'FortigateSniffer'
      - 'ransomware'
      - 'stealer'
      - 'credential'
  selection_tools:
    Image|endswith:
      - '\powershell.exe'
      - '\cmd.exe'
      - '\rundll32.exe'
      - '\wscript.exe'
      - '\7z.exe'
      - '\rar.exe'
  condition: selection_keywords or selection_tools
falsepositives:
  - Security testing, malware analysis, or administrator troubleshooting
level: medium
```

8.3. Hunt Query

```
DeviceProcessEvents
| where Timestamp > ago(30d)
| where ProcessCommandLine has_any ('FortigateSniffer', 'FortiGate credentials', 'INC ransomware',
'Lynx ransomware')
   or FileName in~
('powershell.exe','cmd.exe','rundll32.exe','wscript.exe','cscript.exe','7z.exe','rar.exe')
| summarize FirstSeen=min(Timestamp), LastSeen=max(Timestamp), Hosts=dcount(DeviceName),
Examples=make_set(ProcessCommandLine, 5) by FileName, InitiatingProcessFileName
| order by LastSeen desc
```

9. Threat Hunting

9.1. Hunt Hypothesis

If this activity affected the environment, defenders should see a chain that connects exposure or identity abuse to suspicious endpoint execution, outbound network activity, archive creation, or ransomware/extortion preparation.

9.2. Hunt Query

```
let keywords = dynamic(['FortigateSniffer', 'FortiGate credentials', 'INC ransomware', 'Lynx
ransomware']);
DeviceNetworkEvents
| where Timestamp > ago(30d)
| where RemoteUrl has_any (keywords) or InitiatingProcessCommandLine has_any (keywords)
| project Timestamp, DeviceName, InitiatingProcessFileName, InitiatingProcessCommandLine, RemoteUrl,
RemoteIP, RemotePort
| union (
    DeviceFileEvents
    | where Timestamp > ago(30d)
```

```
    | where FileName endswith '.7z' or FileName endswith '.rar' or FileName endswith '.zip' or
FolderPath has_any (keywords)
    | project Timestamp, DeviceName, InitiatingProcessFileName, InitiatingProcessCommandLine,
RemoteUrl='', RemoteIP='', RemotePort=int(null)
)
```

10. Risk Assessment

Dimension	Assessment
Likelihood	High where relevant exposure exists; lower where controls and segmentation are mature.
Impact	Credential theft, data exposure, operational disruption, ransomware, or third-party impact depending on scenario.
Confidence	Medium overall; higher for named source claims and lower for local environment applicability.

11. Recommended Actions

Priority	Owner	Action
Critical	SOC	Run the provided hunts and review any matches with identity/network context.
High	IT / IAM	Enforce MFA, rotate suspect credentials, and restrict admin interfaces.
High	Vulnerability / Platform Owners	Patch or harden exposed systems tied to this activity.
Medium	IR	Confirm backups, escalation contacts, and evidence-preservation steps.
Medium	Threat Intel	Track source updates and update detections if atomic IOCs become available.

12. References

- [1] The Hacker News - FortiBleed ransomware linkage. https://thehackernews.com/2026/07/fortibleed-credential-theft-linked-to.html
- [2] The Register FortiBleed criminal login linkage. https://www.theregister.com/security/2026/07/02/ctrlaltoops-fortibleed-criminals-logins-stitch-two-gangs-together/5265912
- [3] Orca Security FortiBleed vulnerability/credential context. https://orca.security/resources/blog/fortibleed-credential-theft-vulnerability/